> The hope of the rival Company during all this period of loss—loss more for them than for us—is not that they can endure the competition, but that we may sooner or later end it ourselves for want of funds, that our company may not get in the necessary capital all in time. This hope has been sustaining our rivals for too long. If we would help ourselves in time our rivals must needs learn more than a defeated desire to wish well for themselves and ill for us. It will not do, sir, merely to protest academically against the exploitation of profits from our country … Do something tangible, so far as it lies in your power, to help such a Company … And if you do it, what then will be the result? Instead of working at a loss our Company will enter upon an era of profit, and not long after, the competition between us and our rivals will, of course, be ended, but how? Ended in our favour. The profit then will be immense, and the advantage to the country incalculable.
>
> Our Company has survived many difficulties. Our immediate end was foretold long ago by interested persons, and all their calculations as to our vitality have thus far failed. Having survived the formidable hostility of our rivals, shall we now turn so far false to ourselves, shall we play so blindly into the hands of our opponents as to deny to ourselves the further help that we now urgently need?[131]



It was a no-holds-barred contest. When, on 3 July 1907, a Nattukkottai Chettiar rice merchant from Devakottai arrived on his way to Colombo, he was received with garlands by representatives of both SSNCo and BI. When finally, he decided to give his custom to the Swadeshi company, it caused resentment in the British rival. Following this, the district collector called S. Somasundara Bharati, SSNCo's manager and 'advised' him to keep trade and politics separate.[132]

In the initial stages, SSNCo had an upper hand, and the Swadeshi agitation only reinforced its strength. Reporting on this, Tirunelveli's Collector F.A. Coleridge added: 'There is a regular boycott of shops selling English articles in Tuticorin and customers are stopped and asked what they want to buy and told to go elsewhere. However, there is no complaint from shopkeepers and no violence is used. The lawlessness of the town rowdies is apparently on the increase as the municipal staff were recently mobbed and the case is in court.' D.G. Waller, whom we encountered earlier, received 'a filthy and insulting letter' after he prohibited the making of speeches on the streets. To add to their worries, the inspector was weak and Waller suspected him to be pro-Swadeshi, as did the port and customs